CROWNS & KNIVES

The Donohue Family, the Smilley Dynasty, and the Feud That Divided Black Hollywood

STORY BIBLE — VOLUME 05: THE FAMILIES

All ages are as of the story present: **Friday, April 28, 2006**.

Everyone in this volume is African American. Hollywood around them is as diverse as it really was in 2006, and as white in its executive suites.

“Never forgive a Donohue.”
— Ezekiel “Zeke” Smilley, 1979

1. The Smilley Dynasty: Four Generations

The Smilleys are **old Black Hollywood royalty**. They value pedigree, respectability, dignity on screen, and a family brand built over almost a century. Their estate has been in **View Park**, the Los Angeles neighborhood known as the “Black Beverly Hills,” since 1962. The family's motto, stitched on a sampler in the foyer, reads: **“We do not play the fool.”**

Era	What happened
1920s-1940s The Founders	**Ezekiel “Zeke” Smilley** and his wife **Pearl** start as song-and-dance headliners on the Chitlin' Circuit, the network of Black theaters and clubs. Zeke becomes a star of the race films of the 1930s and '40s, the all-Black-cast movies made for segregated theaters. He refuses every role that has him play a buffoon, and it costs him work. Every dollar he does earn goes into a family trust, the **Smilley Fund**, meant to make sure his grandchildren never have to beg a studio for anything.
1950s-1960s The Breakthrough	Their son **Cornelius Smilley** becomes one of Black Hollywood's first dignified leading men, on Broadway, in live television drama, and in prestige films. In 1964, with money from the Smilley Fund, he co-founds a production company with his closest friend, a young actor named **Victor Donohue**, the son of Gus Donohue, who founded Donohue Entertainment. (See Section 3 and Volume 06.)
1970s-1990s The Rebuild	After losing the company, Cornelius and his wife **Hattie** rebuild through **Smilley Management Group** (founded 1972). It manages the family's own careers and a roster of respected Black actors. Their son **Desmond** becomes a 1980s heartthrob and the dynasty's next leading man.
1980s-today The Heirs	Desmond and his wife **Celeste** raise three children as a deliberate brand: **Julian** the leading man, **Simone** the sitcom darling, and **Esther** the crown jewel, sold as “the modern-day Shirley Temple.” Smilley Management Group runs all three careers. Esther is now the family's biggest earner by far.

Public image: grace, family values, church on Sunday, Image Awards in the trophy case. **Private reality:** pride, control, money pressure (the Smilley Fund has never recovered from the 1960s), and a hatred of the Donohues that is passed down like a family heirloom.

2. The Smilleys: Character Profiles

“Black don't crack”: every Smilley looks well under their real age, and they know it. In this family, youthfulness is a brand asset.

EZEKIEL “ZEKE” SMILLEY (March 9, 1904 – February 2, 1979) — The Founder (deceased)

A vaudeville hoofer turned race-film matinee idol, proud enough to turn down work that would humiliate him. He watched the Smilley Fund disappear in the 1966 deal (see Section 3), and on his deathbed he made his family swear the **Smilley Oath**: *“Never forgive a Donohue.”* His portrait hangs over the fireplace in View Park.

PEARL SMILLEY (née DUPREE) (June 1, 1908 – October 17, 1991) — The Voice (deceased)

A blues and jazz singer and actress who toured the Chitlin' Circuit with Zeke and managed the family's money while he performed. She was the family's real strategist. Pearl never took the Oath herself; she only said, *“Hate is expensive, baby. Somebody always pays.”*

CORNELIUS SMILLEY (born November 3, 1933) — Age 72 (looks late 50s) — The Patriarch

Fame: a living legend. A Tony winner, an Emmy winner and a two-time Oscar nominee, with lifetime achievement honors from the NAACP Image Awards. Black Hollywood treats him as an elder statesman.

Career status: semi-retired. He takes dignified supporting roles as wise elders and judges, and he is typecast as “the noble grandfather,” which bores him.

The secret: Victor Donohue was the best friend he ever had, and Cornelius has never stopped missing him. In public he keeps the Oath. In private he keeps a 1958 photograph of the two of them on a Harlem rooftop. He is the one Smilley who could someday end the feud, and the one who most fears looking weak by trying.

HATTIE SMILLEY (née BOOKER) (born August 14, 1935) — Age 70 (looks early 60s) — The Matriarch

Fame: well known and respected. She was a celebrated stage actress, and in the 1970s and '80s she played a TV-movie mother audiences adored.

Career status: essentially retired. She does a guest role now and then, and she runs the family's charity, the **Pearl Smilley Foundation for the Arts**.

Personality: warm in public and steel in private. She married Cornelius knowing that his first love was Joan Mercer, the woman who later married Victor. Hattie's own grudge against Joan is quieter than the men's, and deeper.

DESMOND SMILLEY (born October 8, 1957) — Age 48 (looks mid-30s) — Esther's Father, the Antagonist

Fame: well known. He was the 1980s heartthrob of romantic dramas and TV miniseries, and his face was on every *Jet* magazine cover in 1984.

Career status: typecast and in a dry spell. He was always “the beautiful one” and never “the serious one.” He has spent twenty years chasing respect, and the prestige roles he wants keep going to other men. He now acts rarely and runs **Smilley Management Group** as its CEO, managing his children's careers.

His defining wound: in 1989, director **Robert Bullock**, Natasha Donohue's husband, fired him from a prestige drama two weeks into the shoot. Robert told *Premiere* magazine: *“Desmond is a beautiful frame with no painting in it.”* The quote follows Desmond everywhere, and he can recite it word for word.

Personality: charming, magnetic and devout in public. In private he is controlling, vain, insecure and vindictive. He loves his children, but he loves the Smilley legacy more, and he can't tell the two apart. Of all the Smilleys, he believes in the Oath the most.

CELESTE SMILLEY (née ARRINGTON) (born March 22, 1960) — Age 46 (looks early 30s) — Esther's Mother, the Image-Maker

Fame: moderately known. She was a runway model with the Ebony Fashion Fair show, then a 1980s daytime soap star.

Career status: semi-retired as an actress. She runs image and branding for Smilley Management Group. She invented the “modern-day Shirley Temple” brand for Esther and protects it fiercely: approved wardrobe, approved roles, approved friends, approved interviews.

Personality: poised and perfectionist, with an eye for how anything will play in the press. She is less vengeful than Desmond but just as controlling. She cares more about scandal than about the feud.

JULIAN SMILLEY (born February 14, 1977) — Age 29 (looks early 20s) — The Eldest, the Golden Son

Fame: well known. He is a romantic-comedy and TV-drama heartthrob, and he was named one of *People*'s “Sexiest Men Alive” in 2003.

Career status: typecast. Studios see him only as the charming love interest. He is desperate for a blockbuster or a prestige role to prove he's more than his father's face. **Right now, in 2006, Desmond is campaigning hard to get Julian cast as Tony Stark in *Iron Man*.**

Personality: charming, competitive and fragile under the confidence. He resents being the vehicle for his father's ambitions, but he has never once said no to him.

SIMONE SMILLEY (born July 30, 1979) — Age 26 (looks early 20s) — The Middle Child, the Former Sitcom Darling

Fame: well known, but fading. She was the adorable little sister on a hit 1990s family sitcom, and now she is mostly a tabloid name.

Career status: a dry spell, and she can't move into adult roles. After her sitcom ended she rebelled: Hollywood nightlife in the Paris Hilton era, paparazzi photos, a stint in rehab. Casting directors still see the sitcom kid or the party girl. She may be the most naturally gifted actor in the family, and nobody gives her the chance to prove it.

Personality: sharp, funny and wounded. She is the family's black sheep and Esther's fiercest protector. **She is the Smilley most likely to side with Esther against their parents.**

ESTHER SMILLEY (born September 20, 1982) — Age 23 (looks late teens) — The Crown Jewel

Fame: a household name. She is an award-winning, critically acclaimed actress and singer, America's sweetheart since childhood, and the modern-day Shirley Temple.

Career status: she can't move into adult roles. Her parents approve only family films, faith-friendly projects and musicals. She is hungry for complex adult work and has been turning down nothing, because she is never shown the scripts. Her contract with Smilley Management Group runs through 2014.

Marc-Anthony: they have been friends since they met backstage at Nickelodeon's Kids' Choice Awards in 1994. They were two kids in the same audition rooms, from two families who hate each other. Their friendship is real, private and protected by the friends they share. They get together in 2011 and marry in 2013. **She will play Thor.**

3. The Feud: Why the Smilleys Hate the Donohues

The feud is not one wound. It is **three generations of wounds**, each reopening the last. Both families tell the story differently, and the truth sits somewhere between them, which is what makes it drama.

Year	Wound
1956	Cornelius Smilley and Victor Donohue meet in the chorus of a Broadway musical. They become inseparable: roommates in Harlem, sharing auditions, rent and dreams. Victor is the hustler and Cornelius is the artist.
1959	**Wound #1: Joan.** Cornelius is engaged to an actress and singer named **Joan Mercer**. Joan breaks off the engagement and in **1960 marries Victor**. Cornelius is the best man at nobody's wedding; he doesn't attend. The friendship survives, barely.
1964	**The partnership.** They reconcile and co-found **Smilley-Donohue Productions**, an independent live-action label distributed by Donohue Entertainment, the studio Victor's father Gus founded in 1923. Victor, who had broken away from his father to act, wants to prove himself outside Gus's shadow. The label makes dignified Black-led films and television. Zeke Smilley puts in the Smilley Fund as seed money, nearly his entire life savings. Victor brings the deals.
1966	**Wound #2: The Takeover.** The label's first hit is a success, and debts come due on the follow-up. On December 15, 1966, Gus Donohue dies, and the board wants an outside CEO. To win control of his father's empire, Victor folds Smilley-Donohue Productions and its hit library into Donohue Entertainment. Cornelius, trusting his friend, signs papers without reading them. When the deal closes, Cornelius has been bought out for a fraction of what the label is worth, mostly in Donohue shares the family still holds (0.08%), and the Smilley Fund is gone. Victor, 30, becomes CEO of Donohue Entertainment.
1967-1971	*Smilley v. Donohue.* Cornelius sues. The lawsuit drags on for four years and Cornelius loses. The judge rules that every signature was legal. The Black press covers it like a divorce, and Black Hollywood has to choose sides.
1979	**The Smilley Oath.** Zeke dies having never recovered his savings or his pride. His last words to his family are *"Never forgive a Donohue."*
1989	**Wound #3: The Frame Quote.** Robert Bullock, Victor's son-in-law, fires Desmond from a prestige film and tells *Premiere* that Desmond is *"a beautiful frame with no painting in it."* Desmond's credibility as a serious actor never recovers.
1997	**The Raid.** One year into her time as CEO, **Natasha Donohue Bullock** lures three of Smilley Management Group's top clients over to Donohue Entertainment. Smilley Management Group nearly collapses.
Today (2006)	The two families are the two great Black Hollywood dynasties. They sit on opposite sides at every awards show, and every host jokes about it. Neither family will appear in a project produced by the other.

Victor's Side of the Story

Victor tells it differently: Cornelius was drinking in 1966, missing meetings, and the label was weeks from bankruptcy. The board would make Victor CEO only if he brought a win. He saved the company, he says, and he paid Cornelius more than his shares were worth on paper. **The full truth of 1966 is a mystery the real-world story will slowly reveal.** It may include a document Cornelius never saw, and a reason Joan really left him.

What each family represents: the Smilleys are old royalty, pedigree and respectability, the family that stayed proud and lost. The Donohues are the empire, power and ownership, the family that made hard choices and won. Each family sees itself as the hero of the story.

4. Why Desmond Smilley Will Hate Marc-Anthony

Desmond inherited the feud with the Donohues. **His hatred of Marc-Anthony is his own.** It builds in stages until it consumes him, and every stage is something Marc did out of love, kindness or talent. That is what makes it so infuriating to Desmond.

#	When	The reason
1	Birth	**Blood.** Marc is Victor Donohue's grandson, Natasha's son and Robert Bullock's son: the living child of every person who ever humiliated the Smilleys.
2	2006	**Iron Man.** Desmond is campaigning to get Julian cast as Tony Stark. **Marc-Anthony gets the role.** Julian's career stalls for good, and Desmond believes Marc stole his son's future the way Victor stole his father's company.
3	2008-2010	**Everything Desmond wanted.** *Iron Man* is a global smash. Marc gets the respect, the prestige, the awards and the power, everything Desmond chased for twenty years. Critics call Marc “the most complete talent of his generation,” the exact opposite of “a beautiful frame with no painting in it.”
4	2007-2010	**The joke.** Marc's unfiltered comedy lands a joke about the Smilleys at a televised event, and the clip spreads all over YouTube. Marc meant it as harmless roasting. Desmond takes it as a public execution.
5	2009-2011	**Thor.** Esther takes the role of Thor against her parents' orders. It's her first adult role and her first act of rebellion, in a film universe built around Marc. Desmond blames Marc's influence.
6	2011	**Esther.** Marc and Esther go public as a couple. To Desmond, the Smilley crown jewel choosing a Donohue grandson is the ultimate betrayal of the Smilley Oath.
7	May 10, 2012	**The twins.** Emma and Victoria are born before the wedding, and the good-girl brand Desmond and Celeste spent 30 years building is gone overnight. Desmond is convinced the name **Victoria** honors Victor Donohue, whether or not it does.
8	2012-2013	**The rule-bender.** Marc discovers that Smilley Management Group has controlled Esther's money and choices for years under an unfair contract. Under California's Talent Agencies Act, a manager without an agent's license who procures work for a client can have the contract voided. Marc finds the paper trail, gets Esther independent lawyers, and frees her. That costs the Smilleys their biggest earner and puts Desmond's handling of her money in the trade papers.
9	2013 onward	**The legacy.** Esther marries Marc. Her children are Bullocks, they adore Marc, and the Smilley line is absorbed into the Bullock-Donohue fortune. Marc's dream of a gigantic family and generational wealth is Desmond's nightmare come true.
10	Always	**The kindness.** Marc never hates him back. He offers Julian roles, donates anonymously to the Pearl Smilley Foundation, invites Desmond to every birthday party and tells reporters he hopes they'll be family someday. The kinder and more beloved Marc is, the more Desmond looks like the villain, and he knows it. He would rather be destroyed than be pitied.

Desmond's endgame: to ruin Marc-Anthony's career by any means necessary: planted stories, leaked rumors, sabotaged deals, recruited allies inside rival studios, and attacks on his reputation. Every attack fails or backfires, because Marc's goodness is real and the public can tell. Each failure makes Desmond more desperate.

5. The Donohue-Bullock Family

The **empire**: Donohue Entertainment, founded in 1923 and headquartered in Burbank (see Volume 06), with the family estate in Bel Air. Ruthless in business and fiercely loyal to family.

Name	Born	Age	Looks	Status in 2006
Victor Donohue	May 30, 1936	69	mid-50s	Billionaire Chairman of Donohue Entertainment (CEO 1966-1996). Actor, singer, producer, director. A legend: feared, revered and never apologetic.
Joan Donohue (née Mercer)	Apr 17, 1938	68	early 50s	Legendary actress, singer, director and filmmaker. Victor's wife since 1960, and the woman at the center of Wound #1.
Natasha Bullock (née Donohue)	June 2, 1961	44	early 30s	CEO of Donohue Entertainment since 1996. An award-winning actress and singer who manages her children's careers. Ruthless and dangerous, and the architect of the 1997 Raid.
Robert Bullock	Feb 10, 1959	47	mid-30s	A respected, powerful, award-winning director. Married to Natasha since 1981. Author of the 1989 “frame” quote.
Elxa Bullock	Aug 29, 1980	25	early 20s	Eldest child. An award-winning actress and TV personality. **Will play Janet van Dyne / the Wasp.**
Marc-Anthony Bullock	Jan 5, 1982	24	late teens	Second child and eldest son. **Will play Tony Stark / Iron Man.** Full profile below.
Grace Bullock	Apr 12, 1994	12	—	Youngest child. An actress and singer, and Marc's ride-or-die. **Will play Wanda Maximoff / Scarlet Witch.**

MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK — Age 24 — Tony Stark / Iron Man

Who he is: a former Donohue Channel and Nickelodeon child star who became a critically acclaimed, award-winning actor, singer, screenwriter, director and producer. He has a reported IQ of 250, natural charisma, distinctive looks, and comedy that is hilarious, unhinged and unfiltered. Canon net worth: over $990 billion and rising every day. He is the most successful, powerful, influential, respected, beloved and charitable person in the world, and he spares no expense.

His heart: he is the sweetest, kindest, most loving, compassionate, innocent and pure man in the world. Children adore him and he adores them. **His number-one dream is a gigantic family**, and children are non-negotiable. He believes in generational wealth.

His code: when a rule or law is unjust, unfair or just plain stupid, he bends it, finds the loophole or takes creative liberties to help people. That trait is exactly what frees Esther from her contract, and exactly what Desmond can never forgive.

The irony at the center of the saga: the Smilleys lost everything in 1966 because of a contract nobody read carefully. Fifty years later, a Donohue grandson frees a Smilley from a contract by reading every word.

6. The Ensemble: Fame and Career Status in April 2006

How famous each person is, rated from 1 (legend) to 5 (rising), with their current career problem. Every one of them is African American.

Actor (age)	MCU role	Fame	Career status and the problem they face
Marc-Anthony Bullock (24)	Tony Stark / Iron Man	2: household name	At the top of his game in music, TV and acclaimed films. The industry's question: can a former Donohue Channel and Nickelodeon kid open a $140M blockbuster? The same doubt Hollywood had about Robert Downey Jr. in real life.
Amond Baker (24)	Bruce Banner / Hulk	3: well known	**Typecast** as the funny best friend since he was a child actor. Casting directors laugh in his auditions before he says a line. Banner is his chance at serious drama. Marc's brother in everything but blood.
Tyrese Avery (24)	Steve Rogers / Captain America	2: global superstar	One of the biggest pop stars in the world. **Critics dismiss his acting** as “a pop star who acts.” Captain America is his chance to be taken seriously.
Esther Smilley (23)	Thor	2: household name	**Can't move into adult roles.** Her parents' good-girl brand keeps her in family films.
Arianna Cummings (23)	Claire Barton / Hawkeye	4: critics' favorite	Acclaimed in indie films and on stage, but still waiting for her breakthrough. Critics know her name and the public doesn't, yet.
Harmony Divine (23)	Natasha Romanoff / Black Widow	4: Broadway famous	An award-winning dancer who moved to Broadway and then screen acting. **Typecast** in dance roles: Hollywood keeps offering her dance movies. Black Widow's combat skills make use of everything she trained for.
Tyler Chapman (24)	Bucky Barnes / Winter Soldier	4: industry known	An actor and musician known from an indie band and a canceled cable drama. **In a dry spell**, picking up guest spots and gigs.
David Tipton (25)	Hank Pym / Ant-Man	4: familiar face	A character actor whose face audiences know but whose name they don't. **Typecast** as the nerd, the lab tech or the scientist, which suits Hank.
Tayia Boyd (24)	Pepper Potts	3: well known	Marc's longtime co-star from Donohue Channel and Nickelodeon, with excellent chemistry. **In a dry spell** since her last series ended in 2004. Casting directors still see her as a kid-show actress.
Elxa Bullock (25)	Janet van Dyne / Wasp	3: well known	An award-winning actress and TV personality. **Seen as a nepotism hire** (“the Donohue princess”), and her TV-host work makes critics doubt her acting.
Grace Bullock (12)	Wanda Maximoff / Scarlet Witch	4: rising	A child actress and singer. Her Donohue Channel series was canceled in 2005 under Natasha's no-family rule (see Volume 07).
Elijah Blackman (12)	Pietro Maximoff / Quicksilver	5: rising	A working child actor in commercials and kid-network guest roles. He hasn't had his big break yet.
Julian Smilley (29)	—	3: well known	**Typecast** as the romantic-comedy heartthrob. Up for Tony Stark against Marc.
Simone Smilley (26)	—	3: fading	**In a dry spell and stuck in kid roles**, with a tabloid reputation.

Actor (age)	MCU role	Fame	Career status and the problem they face
Desmond Smilley (48)	—	3: well known	**Typecast as a pretty face and in a dry spell**, now running Smilley Management Group.

Planned couples: Marc-Anthony and Esther (together 2011, married 2013). Amond and Harmony (together 2013, married 2015).

7. The Next Generation (future canon)

Name	Born	Parents	Profile
Emma Bullock	May 10, 2012 (Thursday)	Marc-Anthony and Esther	The older twin, by 25 minutes. A complete daddy's girl and Marc's twin in talent and personality. Spoiled endlessly but knows the value of hard work. Respectful and responsible. Gen Z raised like a millennial.
Victoria Bullock	May 10, 2012	Marc-Anthony and Esther	The younger twin. Also a daddy's girl who inherited Marc's talent and personality, and also respectful and responsible, but a wild child (a contained one). Gen Z raised like a millennial.
Lyric Baker	April 20, 2014	Amond and Harmony	A sweetheart and an angel. Marc is her godfather. Gen Alpha raised like a millennial.

The twins are born six days after *The Avengers* opens on May 4, 2012.

Open Questions

- **A real-name overlap:** Tyrese Gibson is a real singer and actor who will appear in the real-world story (*Transformers*, 2007). Keep the name Tyrese Avery and acknowledge the overlap in the story, or adjust it?
- **Why the twin is named Victoria:** Desmond is sure it honors Victor Donohue. Should that be true, or is it a coincidence he refuses to believe?
- **The truth about 1966:** do you want to decide what really happened, or should I build the reveal as the story goes?